Polymers

Exam code: 0620 & 0971

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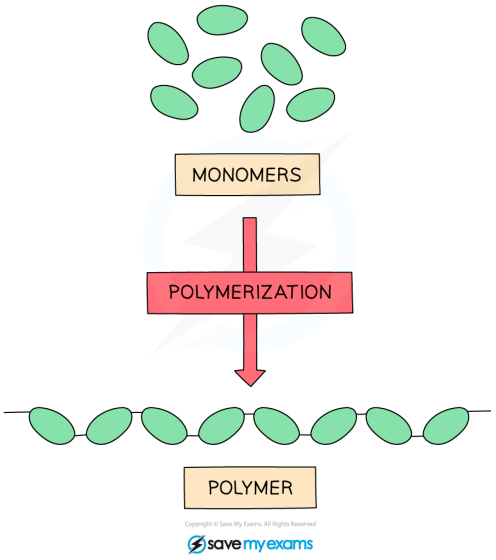
Polymers: the basics

- Polymers are large molecules built up from many smaller molecules called **monomers**



Monomers join together to form long chains (polymers)

- Each monomer is joined to the next by **covalent bonds**
- Examples of polymers include:
  - Poly(ethene)
  - PVC
  - Nylon

Addition polymerisation

- Poly(ethene) is formed by the **addition polymerisation** of ethene monomers
- Ethene is an **alkene**, so it contains a carbon–carbon double bond (C=C)
- During addition polymerisation:
  - The C=C double bond in each monomer breaks
  - The monomers join together to form a long-chain polymer
  - **Only one product is formed**
- Many ethene monomers join together to form **poly(ethene)**

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Poly(ethene) is formed by addition polymerisation using ethene monomers

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